READING PASSAGE 1

*You should spend about 20 minutes on **Questions 1-13**, which are based on Reading Passage 1.*

Portrait of Bianca Sforza

Leonardo da Vinci's Lost Masterpiece

In 2010, a discovery shook the art world. A portrait of a young woman, purchased at a small auction in Switzerland for a modest sum, was identified by some experts as a previously unknown work by Leonardo da Vinci. The painting, known as La Bella Principessa, depicts Bianca Sforza, the illegitimate daughter of Ludovico Sforza, Duke of Milan. If authentic, it would not only expand da Vinci's already extraordinary oeuvre, but also change our understanding of his work during the late 15th century.

The portrait's journey into the limelight began when Canadian art collector Peter Silverman acquired it. At first glance, the delicate image seemed like a typical Renaissance portrait. However, certain details — the subtle shading of the sitter's face, the exquisite treatment of her hair, and the ethereal quality of the gaze — suggested a hand far more skilled than the German artist to whom it had previously been attributed. Suspecting something greater, Silverman enlisted the help of leading da Vinci expert Martin Kemp.

Kemp, emeritus professor of art history at Oxford University, had spent decades studying Leonardo's techniques. Upon examining the portrait, he was struck by several features. The sitter's hairstyle and costume matched Milanese fashion of the 1490s, and the fine lines of the drawing displayed Leonardo's characteristic sfumato technique — the subtle blending of tones without abrupt edges. Moreover, the use of vellum — a material made from calfskin — was consistent with Leonardo's known experiments during his Milanese period.

To bolster the claim of authenticity, scientific tests were conducted. Multispectral imaging revealed a series of faint fingerprint marks on the surface of the portrait. These prints, made in the paint layer before it dried, were compared with known fingerprints from Leonardo's notebooks. Astonishingly, there appeared to be a partial match, suggesting that Leonardo himself might have handled the work. Further analysis of the pigments confirmed that they were consistent with materials available in the late 15th century.

Nevertheless, the attribution remains controversial. Critics argue that the portrait lacks the dynamism and innovation typical of Leonardo's other works. Carmen Bambach, curator at the Metropolitan Museum of Art, is among those who remain unconvinced. She suggests that, while the portrait is of high quality, it could have been created by one of Leonardo's pupils or a talented contemporary imitator. Such doubts are not uncommon in the world of Old Master attributions, where connoisseurship and scientific evidence often clash.

Adding to the intrigue is the identity of the sitter. Historical records indicate that Bianca Sforza was married at a young age to Galeazzo Sanseverino, a prominent Milanese courtier. Tragically, she died shortly thereafter at the age of 14, possibly from childbirth complications. The portrait's subtle melancholy, combined with the youthful features of the sitter, supports the theory that it may have been commissioned to commemorate her short life.

The debate surrounding La Bella Principessa reflects broader challenges in art authentication. As technology advances, tools such as carbon dating, digital microscopy, and chemical analysis provide new insights. Yet they rarely offer conclusive answers. In the case of this portrait, scientific findings, historical context, and stylistic analysis each tell part of the story, but none can definitively declare Leonardo's authorship.

For now, La Bella Principessa remains both a tantalising possibility and a symbol of art history's enduring mysteries. Whether or not it is confirmed as a work by Leonardo, the portrait has captured the imagination of scholars and the public alike. As Martin Kemp once remarked, "Even if we can never be 100 percent certain, the dialogue between art and science has brought us closer than ever before to understanding this beautiful, enigmatic figure."

词汇 / 术语	中文释义	用法 / 语境说明
attribution	归属、归因	e.g. *The attribution of the painting to Leonardo remains controversial.* 用于艺术品是否属于某位艺术家的判断。
sfumato	“渐隐法”	一种柔和过渡的绘画技法，达 · 芬奇标志性风格，强调边缘的模糊与光影的融合。
vellum	犊皮纸	用小牛皮制成的高级纸张，常用于中世纪手稿或珍贵画作。
multispectral imaging	多光谱成像技术	一种科学检测方法，用于观察颜料层下的细节，如画家的草图或指纹痕迹。
fingerprint match	指纹匹配	在艺术鉴定中用于确定画作是否与艺术家本人有物理接触。
connoisseurship	鉴赏力、鉴定专业知识	多用于讨论艺术品鉴定中主观判断与专业经验的重要性。
Old Master	古典大师	指欧洲文艺复兴到18世纪之间的重要艺术家群体，如达 · 芬奇、拉斐尔等。
pupil / studio assistant	学徒 / 工作室助手	达 · 芬奇等艺术大师常有工作室，助手可能代为完成部分作品，增加归属争议。
posthumous attribution	身后归属	指艺术家去世多年后被认定的新作品。
lost work	失落之作	指据文献记载存在但下落不明的作品，若再度出现，将极具轰动性与争议。
commemorative portrait	纪念性肖像	可能为纪念早逝者、特殊时刻而创作的画作，常带有感伤氛围。
Milanese fashion / court	米兰宫廷 / 米兰时尚	15世纪米兰为重要文化中心，作品服饰与背景可与当时风格对照。
art authentication	艺术品鉴定	涉及科学分析、历史考据与艺术风格判断，是整个话题的核心概念。
stylistic analysis	风格分析	通过绘画技法、线条特征等判断作者身份的分析方法。